

THE MONEY YOU GAVE HIM

The Nigerian Woman's Guide to Money, Love and the Word No

The Connection Code

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Before You Start

This book is about money in a relationship you chose and can still walk out of. It is not about abuse.

If a partner holds your bank card, controls your salary, tracks your spending, or if saying no to him has ever made you afraid for your physical safety, that is a different problem with a different answer. No book fixes it. Chapter 8 tells you where to go, and the services listed there are free and confidential.

Everything else in these pages assumes you have a choice you have not been using. Most women reading this do.

WHAT THIS BOOK IS NOT

This is not financial advice, legal advice, or therapy. It is a practical guide to a specific situation, built from experiences Nigerian women commonly describe and from public regulation. Where money or law is involved, it tells you what to ask and who to ask. It does not tell you what to do with your savings, and it does not diagnose anybody.

ABOUT THE WOMEN IN THIS BOOK

The women in this book are composite examples, drawn from experiences Nigerian women commonly describe. Their names, ages and details are illustrative, not real people. What happens to them is what happens to a lot of women, and that is why their stories are here.

INTRODUCTION: The Receipt You Never Kept

You have the transfer screen open. He's asked for ₦60,000, there's ₦84,000 in the account, and rent is due in five weeks. You already know you're going to send it. The only thing you're still deciding is whether you'll say anything first.

That's the moment this book is about. Not the breakup. Not the big betrayal. The ninety seconds before you press send, when you know exactly what you're doing and do it anyway.

If you've been there more than three times, you're not confused. You're stuck. Those are different problems and they need different books. This is the one for stuck.

The part nobody says out loud

Nigerian women are funding Nigerian men, quietly, at a scale that only shows up when somebody finally talks about it.

Tolu was twenty, running an online business. She gave ₦500,000 and never saw it again. Her business failed while it was happening. Looking back, she said: *"How did I not see it? How was I that foolish?"*

Ifeoma was twenty-three, a machine learning engineer earning about nine hundred dollars a month. Over roughly two years she gave ₦600,000. Her explanation is the most honest sentence in this entire book: *"I felt obligated and guilty, so I continued giving in."*

Amaka was twenty, a student on a ₦20,000 weekly allowance. She gave ₦70,000 over eight months. What happened when she couldn't pay is the thing you'll recognise: *"He'd withdraw and act distant if I told him I couldn't help."*

Bisi was thirty-three and earned ₦85,000 a month as a kitchen steward. *"He collected my ATM card and spent all my hard-earned money."*

Four women. Four income brackets. Four completely different lives. The same shape.

Why you couldn't stop

Here's what the advice gets wrong. Everyone treats this as a discipline problem, so everyone offers discipline solutions. Budget better. Value yourself more. Know your worth.

You've heard all of that. You have a budget. You know your worth on paper. None of it survives contact with the actual moment, because the actual moment isn't about money at all.

It's about what happens in the three days after you say no.

That's the whole mechanism, and Chapter 2 pulls it apart properly. Once you can see it working, you stop reading his silence as a verdict on you. That single shift is worth more than every budgeting tip in this book, and the rest of the book exists to give you something to do with it.

What this book will not tell you to do

It won't tell you to leave him. That might be where you end up. It's not where we start, and anyone who opens with it has stopped paying attention to why you're still here.

It won't tell you how to change him, manage him, or get him to see reason. That's a different genre and it doesn't work. Everything here is about what you do, said in words you can actually use.

It won't promise you'll get your money back. Some of it you might. Most of it you probably won't. Chapter 5 is honest about which is which.

It won't guarantee he stays. No book can promise that and every book that does is lying to you. What this book can tell you is what it means if he doesn't, which is Chapter 8.

How to use the next eight chapters

Read Chapters 1 and 2 before you do anything else. They're short, and they're the part that changes how the rest lands.

Chapter 3 gives you a number. It's the hardest chapter and the most useful one. Do not skip it because you think you already know the amount. You don't.

Chapters 4 through 7 are the toolkit. Four ways to say no. Three ways to ask for money back. One chapter on loan apps that you'll want even if you've never taken one. Four questions that make the next decision for you.

Chapter 8 is for after.

Eleven scripts in total, written to be said out loud or typed into WhatsApp with your own name swapped in. Use them exactly. Changing the wording to be softer is how they stop working, and you'll be tempted.

THE ONE THING TO TAKE FROM THIS BOOK

When he goes quiet after you refuse him, the silence is doing a job. It is not evidence that you failed him, that you are selfish, or that you have damaged something precious. It is the mechanism that has kept you paying. Once you can name it while it is happening, it loses most of its power.

Start with the first ₦3,000.

CHAPTER 1: Three Thousand Naira

Nobody's first transfer is ₦600,000.

It's three thousand for data. It's five for a bolt. It's two because his account is under review and he'll send it back on Friday. It's small enough that refusing would make you look difficult over nothing, and that's not an accident. That's the design.

Woman after woman describes the same opening move. Requests that start around ₦3,000. Then ₦8,000. Then the number stops being the point.

Zainab was twenty. Her story is just amounts: ₦5,000, ₦2,000, ₦5,000 again. No single transfer was worth arguing about. That's how it accumulated.

The first ask is always reasonable

Pay attention to this, because it's the part you'll defend him on.

The first request is usually genuine. His account really is frozen. He really did have an emergency. You really could spare it. You gave it freely and it felt good, because giving to someone you love does feel good, and anybody who tells you that instinct is a flaw is selling you something.

The problem isn't the first transfer. It's that the first transfer answers a question he hadn't asked out loud yet, which is whether you're a person he can ask.

You are. Now he knows.

THE MISTAKE ALMOST EVERYBODY MAKES

Looking for the moment he became a different person. There usually isn't one. The man who asked for ₦3,000 and the man asking for ₦60,000 are the same man, running the same move, with an updated sense of what you'll say yes to. You are not looking for a villain. You are looking for a pattern.

The four stages

These stories tend to move through the same four stages. Not all of them reach stage four. The ones that do usually take many months, sometimes years, to get there.

Stage one: the favour. Small, specific, time-limited. There's a reason attached and usually a repayment date. It may even come back. If it comes back, that matters, because it buys trust for stage two.

Stage two: the pattern. Requests get regular. The repayment date stops being mentioned and you stop asking about it, because asking feels petty against the size of what you two have. The amounts creep up in a way that's invisible per transfer and obvious per quarter.

Stage three: the expectation. He stops asking and starts informing. *"Send me 20k."* The framing changes from request to logistics. This is the stage where refusing produces a reaction, because by now it isn't a favour being declined, it's a standing arrangement being broken.

Stage four: the arrangement. Your money is part of how he lives. He may have stopped earning, or stopped trying, or started something you're funding. Bisi's partner had her card. Ifeoma, the engineer from the Introduction, had a plan where whoever made it first would lift the other. Then, in her words: *"I got my big break, and he became a liability."*

The stages aren't a moral ladder. Nobody's a fool for being at stage three. They're a map, and the only thing they're for is locating yourself.

Where you are right now

Read these four and pick the one that's true today. Not the one that's fair to him.

You're at stage one if the last three requests all had a reason, a rough amount, and at least one of them came back.

You're at stage two if you'd have to check your bank app to tell me how much went out last month, and you have a feeling it's more than you'd say out loud.

You're at stage three if you can predict roughly when the next request is coming, and if you've already imagined how he'd react to a no.

You're at stage four if your own bills have moved because of his, or if he has access to your account, card or app.

If you picked three or four, the rest of this book is aimed straight at you. If you picked one or two, you're in the easiest position you will ever be in to stop this, and you should not waste it.

YOUR MOVE

Write down the stage number on your phone. One digit. You'll check it again at the end of Chapter 3, after you've seen the real figure, and a fair number of women move themselves up a stage at that point.

What this chapter changes

The escalation isn't your weakness showing up. It's a sequence, it has stages, and it runs roughly the same way whether you earn twenty thousand a week or nine hundred dollars a month. Being in it says nothing about your intelligence. Tolu was running a business. Ifeoma was an engineer.

What keeps you in it is a separate thing, and it isn't money.

It's what he does with silence.

CHAPTER 2: He Goes Quiet and You Reach for Your Phone

You said you couldn't do it this time.

He didn't shout. He said "okay" and that was the end of the conversation. Then the replies got shorter. Then they came an hour late, then four hours late. He was online. You checked. By the second evening you were rereading your own message wondering if it sounded harsh, and by the third day you sent the money without being asked again.

Amaka described exactly this. *"He'd withdraw and act distant if I told him I couldn't help."*

That's not a mood. That's a mechanism.

What the silence is doing

Refusing him costs you nothing financially. It costs you about seventy-two hours of a very specific kind of discomfort, and you'll pay tens of thousands of naira to avoid those 72 hours. You've been doing that for months.

Here's why it works so well on you specifically.

The silence doesn't accuse you of anything. If he said "you're selfish", you'd have something to argue with, and you'd probably win. Silence gives you nothing to push against. So you fill it yourself, and what you fill it with is always worse than anything he'd have said out loud.

You supply the accusation. That's the elegance of it.

READ THIS TWICE

The withdrawal is not him being hurt. The withdrawal is the price of the word no, and you have been paying it so reliably that neither of you has to discuss the arrangement anymore. You already know the exchange rate. Three days of cold for ₦60,000.

Why the guilt arrives on schedule

Ifeoma gave the cleanest account of it: *"I felt obligated and guilty, so I continued giving in."*

Obligated first. Guilty second. That order is worth sitting with.

The obligation came from somewhere real. Maybe he helped you once. Maybe you earn more and the imbalance embarrasses you both. Maybe you said something early on, before you understood where it was going, and now you feel bound to it. Ifeoma had a whole pact about it.

The guilt is what shows up when you try to act against the obligation. It's not information. It's resistance, and resistance always arrives strongest at exactly the moment you're about to change something.

Bisi's version was quieter and harder to hear: *"I convinced myself I was lucky. I didn't think I could do better."* At thirty-three, earning ₦85,000 a month, funding a man who contributed nothing.

That sentence isn't about money either.

The three-day pattern

Track it once and you'll never unsee it. Almost every version runs like this.

Day one. Clipped replies. Nothing you could point to. If you asked, he'd say he's fine, and technically he would be.

Day two. The gap widens. He's active on WhatsApp and not answering you. You start drafting messages you don't send. This is the day most women break.

Day three. Either you send money, or you send an apology that isn't about money but functions exactly like one. Warmth returns immediately. That speed is the tell. Genuine hurt doesn't switch off the moment a transfer lands.

Day four. Everything's normal. Nobody mentions it. The arrangement is now slightly stronger than it was last week, because it survived a test.

You can set your calendar by this. Do it. Watching it run on schedule strips out most of its force, because the thing only works while you believe it's a real emotional event happening to a real person in real time.

THE TRAP INSIDE THIS CHAPTER

Do not take this to him as an accusation. "I know what you're doing with the silence" starts a fight you cannot win, because he will deny it, you will have no proof, and you will end up apologising. This chapter is for you to see with. It is not a weapon and it will not work as one.

Naming it out loud

Not to him. To yourself, and ideally to one other person.

Saying it out loud does something that thinking it does not. It converts a feeling into a fact with a shape, and facts with shapes can be planned around.

SCRIPT 1. For one trusted person.

"I want to tell you something and I don't want advice, I just want one person to know it. I've been giving [name] money for about [time]. When I say no, he goes cold for a few days and I end up sending it anyway. I'm trying to stop and I think I need somebody else to know that's

what I'm doing."

Pick someone who won't tell you to leave him in the first sentence. A sister who'll escalate it to your mother is the wrong choice. What you need is a witness, not a rescue.

If there is genuinely nobody, write it in your notes app with today's date. It's weaker, but it's not nothing, and it gives you something to look back at in six weeks.

DO THIS NOW

Open your calendar. When the next refusal happens, put a note on day one that just says "day 1". Then day 2 and day 3. Watching the pattern keep to its own timetable is the single most deflating thing you can do to it.

What this chapter changes

You've been reading three days of cold as a measure of how much you hurt him. It's a price. Prices are set by whoever's collecting, and this one has been set high because you've always paid it.

You still don't know what you've paid in total.

That number exists. It's in your bank app right now, and it's the next chapter.

CHAPTER 3: The Number You Have Never Added Up

Every woman reading this has a figure in her head. Every one of those figures is wrong, and it's wrong in the same direction.

Ask a woman what she's given her boyfriend over the last year and she'll name the biggest single transfer she remembers. ₦200,000, say. The real total is often much higher, because the mind holds onto the dramatic transfers and drops the ordinary ones, and the ordinary ones are where the money actually went.

Zainab's story is five thousand here, two thousand there. Add up a year of that and it's not small anymore.

You're going to find the real number today. It takes about forty minutes.

Why the number does the work

You've tried deciding to stop. It didn't hold, and you already know why. A decision made from feeling gets undone by a different feeling three days later.

A number doesn't move. You can look at it on a bad night, at the exact moment you're about to send ₦60,000, and it says the same thing it said on a good morning.

There's a second reason, and it's the one that catches most women off guard. The total is almost always large enough to be visible against something real in your life. A relocation fund. A deposit. A car. A year of rent. Until you see it that way, the money is abstract. Once you can say "this is the flight and six months of rent in Ontario", the arithmetic stops being about him.

WHY FORTY MINUTES BEATS SIX MONTHS OF WILLPOWER

A resolution is a feeling and feelings expire. A total is a fact and facts do not. Women who have been through this can name their totals afterwards. Almost never while it's still happening.

Rebuilding twelve months

Open your bank app. Both banks, if you have two. Your Opay or Moniepoint or Kuda as well, because a lot of this went out through the app you use for small transfers, and small transfers are the whole point.

Go back twelve months. Not three. Twelve.

Search his name and his phone number separately. People save the same person twice. Check the account name on transfers too, because money sent to "PAUL C OKONKWO" won't come up under "Baby".

Write down every outgoing transfer to him. Date and amount. Nothing else, no notes, no explanation of what it was for. The explanations are how you'll talk yourself out of counting things.

Then add these, which almost everyone forgets:

- Money you sent to someone else on his behalf. His brother's school fees. His mechanic. His landlord.
- Things you bought that live at his place.
- Bills of yours he was supposed to split and didn't, if there was an agreement.
- Cash. Estimate honestly and low.
- Airtime and data. It looks trivial. Twelve months of it is not.

What counts and what does not

Counts: anything you gave with an expectation, spoken or not, that it was helping him rather than enjoying each other. Anything that left you short. Anything you'd feel strange telling your closest friend about.

Does not count: gifts you chose freely, with no request behind them, that you'd give again tomorrow. Birthdays. A shirt you saw and liked for him. Dates you wanted to be on.

That distinction matters and it's not a technicality. The point of this exercise is not to prove he's a bad man or to bill him. It's to see the size of one specific thing: the money that left because he asked and you couldn't say no.

Real generosity belongs to you. Don't let this chapter take it.

DO NOT SEND HIM THIS LIST

You are going to be tempted. It will feel like proof, and proof feels like power. It is not. Presenting a spreadsheet to a partner produces a fight about the spreadsheet, and within ten minutes you will be defending a figure from March instead of talking about what happens next. This total is for your eyes. Chapter 5 covers asking for money back, and it does not involve a list.

The tracker

One page. Five columns. Keep it in your notes app or a paper notebook, whichever he can't see.

Date	Amount	What he said it was for	Did it come back	Running total

--	--	--	--	--

That fourth column is the one that earns its place. Most women have never looked at their own repayment rate as a percentage, and it is usually a very short conversation with reality.

Chioma, twenty-two, got her ₦30,000 back eventually. She's the exception, not the rule.

Going forward, log every transfer on the day it happens. Sixty seconds. Do it before you close the banking app, because you will not do it later.

YOUR MOVE

1. Forty minutes, twelve months, both apps. Get the total.
2. Write it at the top of the tracker page.
3. Underneath it, write one thing that exact amount would have paid for.
4. Screenshot that page. When the next request comes, open the screenshot before you open the transfer screen.

When the number lands

Give yourself an hour with it. Most women have one of three reactions, and all three are normal.

Some go straight to anger, at him. That's usable fuel but it burns fast, and it tends to produce a confrontation you're not ready for yet.

Some go straight to shame, at themselves. Tolu's *"how was I that foolish?"* is that reaction exactly, and it's the most common one. Nothing about the number says you were stupid. It says a sequence ran on you and nobody had described it to you before. That's what Chapters 1 and 2 were for.

Some feel nothing at all. That's not coldness. It's the gap between knowing a thing and believing it, and the belief usually arrives two or three days later, often at an odd moment.

Whichever one you get, don't act on it tonight. Not one message. The number has waited this long and it'll keep until you've read the next chapter.

What this chapter changes

You now have something you didn't have this morning: a fact that doesn't argue back. It doesn't care whether tonight is a good night or a bad one. It'll still be the same number in three days when he's cold and you're rereading your own messages.

Go back and check the stage you wrote down in Chapter 1. Quite a few women move themselves up one after seeing the total.

Next is the part you've been avoiding, which is the actual sentence. Four of them, for the four situations that really happen.

CHAPTER 4: The First No

The reason your last refusal didn't hold isn't that you weren't firm enough. It's that you explained.

You said you couldn't this month because rent was coming and your sister needed something and work had been slow. Every word of it true. And every reason you gave him was a problem he could solve. Rent isn't till the 30th. Your sister can wait. He only needs it for a week.

You didn't refuse. You opened negotiations, and you handed him the agenda.

A no that works has no reasons in it.

Why this feels impossible

Because a bare no sounds rude, and you've been trained your whole life to soften. Adding the reason is how you stay a good person while declining. It's reflexive and it's well meant.

It's also the exact mechanism by which you end up sending the money. The reason is the handle. Give him a handle and he'll pull it, not because he's cruel, but because it's right there.

So the scripts below are short in a way that will feel uncomfortable the first time. That discomfort is the cost, and it is far cheaper than what you've been paying.

THE RULE THAT MAKES EVERY SCRIPT WORK

State the decision. Do not supply the reason. "I can't do it" is complete. The urge to add "because" is the urge that has emptied your account for the last eight months.

Before you say any of them

Pick your number first. Right now, before the next request arrives.

Decide the amount you will not go above this month, and decide it while you're calm, because you will not be calm in the moment. Write it next to your total from Chapter 3.

Then pick which of the four situations below is most likely to come first. Read that script four or five times until the words feel like yours. Say it to the mirror once. It sounds ridiculous and it works, because the first time you say these words should not be the time it counts.

Situation one: he asks in person

Hardest, because his face is right there and silence in a room is heavier than silence on a screen.

SCRIPT 2.

"I can't do that one."

[He asks why, or waits.]

"I've just got to be careful this month. I'm sorry."

[He pushes.]

"I know. I still can't."

That's it. Three short moves. The third is the one that matters and it's the one you'll want to skip.

"I know. I still can't" works because it concedes the feeling and holds the decision. He said it's urgent. You're not arguing that it isn't. You're declining anyway, and there's nothing left to argue with.

Say it in the same tone both times. Flat, warm, ordinary. Not cold, not apologetic. If your voice goes up at the end it becomes a question, and he'll answer it.

Then change the subject. Actually change it. Ask about his day. The refusal ends when you stop treating it as the topic.

Situation two: he asks on WhatsApp

Easier, and most requests come this way, which is good news you should use.

SCRIPT 3, warm register.

"I can't manage it this time. Sorry love."

Usually provokes: nothing immediately, then the cold. Use this one while you're still testing whether he'll take a no at all.

SCRIPT 3, firm register. For when the warm one has stopped working, or when this is the fourth request this month.

"I can't send anything this month. I'm not upset with you and I'm not negotiating it. This is just where my money is."

Usually provokes: a direct push back, sometimes anger, occasionally relief that it's finally been said. It's the stronger script and it costs more to send. Don't start here.

Either way, send it. Then put the phone down for twenty minutes.

The twenty minutes is the actual technique. What kills you on WhatsApp is watching the typing indicator appear and disappear, then filling the gap with a second message that walks the first one back. Every woman does this. "Sorry, I know it's bad timing." "Maybe next week?" "How much do you need exactly?"

That second message is the money. Not the first one.

THE FOLLOW-UP MESSAGE

Do not send a second message. Whatever you are about to add is a softener, and softeners are where the negotiation restarts. If you genuinely cannot stop yourself, close WhatsApp and open something else. Twenty minutes. That is the entire skill.

Situation three: he gets angry

Rarer than you fear, and it usually shows up as cold rather than loud. But if it goes hot, the script changes, because you're no longer declining a request. You're in a different conversation.

SCRIPT 4.

"I'm not going to talk about it while you're shouting at me. We can talk later."

Then leave the room, or end the call. Do not stay and absorb it.

Later, if he raises it again:

"My answer's the same. I'm not discussing the money again."

Notice what's missing. No defence of your reasoning, because your reasoning was never the issue. No apology for the anger, because it isn't yours to apologise for.

If anger at a refusal about money is frequent, or if it has ever made you afraid, stop using this script and read Chapter 8 tonight. That isn't a money problem and this chapter is the wrong tool for it.

Situation four: it's an emergency

The hardest one to refuse, and the most likely to be genuine. Sometimes it really is his mother's hospital bill.

You don't have to decide whether it's true. That's the trap. Judging the honesty of an emergency is a losing game where you're either a fool or heartless, and you'll never have the information to win it.

Decide on capacity instead.

SCRIPT 5.

"I don't have that. I can do [smaller amount you genuinely won't miss] and that's my limit, or I can help you work out who else to ask."

Name a real figure. Small enough to be true.

The second half isn't a brush-off. Offering to help him think through who else to ask is what you'd do for any friend in trouble, and it does two useful things. It keeps you a person who shows up, which you are. And it quietly surfaces whether you've been the only name on the list for a long time.

DO THIS NOW

1. Decide your monthly ceiling and write it next to your total.
2. Pick the situation most likely to come up first.
3. Read that script five times. Say it out loud once.
4. Screenshot it and keep it where you can reach it inside ten seconds.

After the no

Expect three days of cold. You know what it is now.

Do not check whether he's online. Do not draft the message. If you make it past day three you've proved something to yourself that no amount of reading can prove, and the next refusal costs you far less than this one did.

If you send the money on day two, you haven't failed the book. Log it in the tracker, note which day you broke on, and try again. Plenty of women don't hold the first one. It gets easier each time you try.

What this chapter changes

You have four sentences that work, and you understand why explaining destroys them.

Stopping the outflow is the first half. The second half is the money already gone, and whether any of it is worth chasing.

CHAPTER 5: Asking for It Back

Start with the part most books skip.

Most of it isn't coming back.

Of the women in this book, one got her money back. Chioma, twenty-two, ₦30,000, eventually. Tolu's ₦500,000, gone. Ifeoma's ₦600,000, gone. The pattern isn't ambiguous and pretending otherwise would waste your time.

So this chapter isn't about recovery. It's about asking once, cleanly, so the question stops living in your head rent free.

When to ask and when to let it go

Ask if any of these are true.

There was a stated repayment date, even a vague one. He's currently earning. The amount is large enough to matter to your life right now. Or you want to know what he'll do, because his answer tells you something you need.

That last one is the real reason most of the time, and it's a perfectly good reason. Asking is a test, and the result is information you can use.

Let it go if you'd only be asking to punish him, if the amount genuinely won't change anything, or if you already know the answer and just want him to say it. You don't need him to confess. You have the tracker.

WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY BUYING

You are not buying the money back. You are buying an answer, and an answer ends a question that has been running in your head for months. A closed question is worth more than most of the amounts involved.

Ask once, not repeatedly

One ask, one follow-up if he gives you a date. That's the whole budget.

Asking repeatedly turns you into the problem. You become the nagging girlfriend in a story where he's the one who owes money, and the conversation stops being about the debt within about two exchanges. You've probably already watched this happen.

One clean ask. Then you decide based on what he does, not on what he says.

Three ways to ask

SCRIPT 6. The soft ask, for a recent amount with a date attached.

"Hey, when do you think you'll be able to sort out the [amount] from [month]? Just trying to plan my month."

"Just trying to plan my month" is doing real work there. It gives the question a purpose that isn't an accusation, which makes it much harder to be offended by.

SCRIPT 7. The direct ask, for something older or larger.

"I need to talk about the money I've lent you. It's got to around [amount] now and I need to start getting it back. Can we work out something you can actually manage?"

Two things make this one work.

"It's got to around [amount]" states the figure without presenting evidence. No screenshots, no list, no dates. You're not prosecuting, you're informing.

"Something you can actually manage" hands him a way to say yes. ₦10,000 a month from a man who owes you ₦300,000 isn't justice, but it's movement, and movement tells you where you stand.

SCRIPT 8. The written record, for after he agrees.

Send this on WhatsApp within an hour of the conversation.

"Just so we both remember. [Amount], starting [date], [how much] a month. Thanks for sorting it."

No hostility. Just a timestamped record that exists outside both your memories. If he agreed, it costs him nothing. If he didn't mean it, watch what he does with this message.

DO NOT TURN THIS INTO A CONTRACT

Some advice will tell you to draw up a loan agreement and get it signed. In a live relationship that escalates the situation into something neither of you can walk back, and it will not make an unwilling person pay. A WhatsApp message is enough of a record for the purpose it serves here. If the sums are large enough that you are thinking about legal action, stop reading advice and speak to a lawyer, which is a real option and not a dramatic one.

What his answer tells you

He pays, or starts paying. Take it seriously. It's rarer than it should be and it means something.

He gets angry. He's converting a debt into a fight about respect, because a fight about respect is one he can win. Do not follow him into it. *"I'm not arguing about it. The money's still there."* Then leave it.

He agrees and does nothing. The most common outcome. Notice it. Two agreed dates come and go, and you now have your answer without anybody having to say it out loud.

He turns it around. Everything he's spent on you, everything he's done, the fact that you're keeping score. Nneka's boyfriend, on the loan she took for him, said: *"I didn't force you to go to the loan apps."*

Sit with that sentence for a second. Technically accurate. Completely beside the point. That's what this move sounds like, and once you've heard it named you'll recognise it instantly.

He disappears. Chioma's description of what she suspected was a pattern: *"Ask them for money and ghost them afterwards."* If he vanishes over a single polite request for money he owes, the request did you a favour and it was cheap at the price.

YOUR MOVE

1. Decide today whether you are asking. Either answer is fine.
2. If yes, pick your script and send it within forty-eight hours, or you will not send it.
3. Whatever he says, write his answer in your tracker.
4. Do not ask twice.

What this chapter changes

You've asked once, in words that don't start a fight, and you've got your answer. The money is either coming or it isn't, and either way it's no longer an open loop.

One thing left before the toolkit's complete, and it's the one that turns a bad situation into a years-long one.

CHAPTER 6: Never Take a Loan for a Man

Nneka was twenty. A student. Her boyfriend needed money she didn't have, so she went to the loan apps and borrowed ₦121,000.

It became ₦300,000.

She didn't spend it. She never saw it. She's the one who repaid it, and when she raised it with him his answer was: *"I didn't force you to go to the loan apps."*

If you read one chapter of this book twice, this is it. Not because you've done it. Because the night you consider it, you'll be in exactly the state where the idea makes sense, and this chapter needs to already be in your head by then.

What actually happened to that number

₦121,000 became ₦300,000. That's roughly two and a half times, and it didn't take years.

Short-tenure digital loans work on cycles of days or weeks, not months. Miss the date and a late fee lands, then the balance rolls into a new cycle and charges apply to the new, larger figure. Miss again and it happens to a bigger number.

This is why people describe the total running away from them. It isn't that they stopped trying. It's that the thing compounds faster than a salary arrives.

THE SENTENCE THAT PRECEDES ALMOST EVERY ONE OF THESE

"I'll just take it and he'll pay it back before the due date." He will not. Not because he is lying to you, necessarily, but because the reason he needed your money in the first place has not changed by Friday. You are not borrowing against his repayment. You are borrowing against your own income, and you are the only person the app is going to come after.

Why "he'll pay it back" fails

Three reasons, and all three are structural.

His timeline isn't yours. You have a fixed date and an automatic penalty. He has an intention. Those aren't the same kind of object, and yours is the one with teeth.

The debt is invisible to him. He never saw the app, the countdown, the reminders. It sits entirely on your phone. Debt you can't see is easy to deprioritise, and it's genuinely hard to hold urgency about a number you've never looked at.

The loan changes the relationship's shape. You're now in trouble because of him, which gives him a reason to avoid the subject, and avoidance is the last thing you can afford when there's a date attached.

If you have already taken one

No lecture. Four steps, in order.

One. Get the real figure today. Open every app. Write down what's owed on each, the due date, and the daily or weekly charge. Put them in order of which one costs most to be late on. That's your repayment order, not the biggest balance.

Two. Stop the source. You can't repay a loan while the reason you took it is still running. The scripts in Chapter 4 exist for this. This is the point where the outflow has to close.

Three. Tell one person. Not for money. For the fact that you said it out loud, because the shame around loan-app debt is what keeps women paying it in silence while it compounds.

Four. Ask the lender about restructuring, in writing. Some will agree to a payment plan. Ask in the app's chat so there's a record. Do not take a new loan to pay an old one, which is the single move that turns a bad month into a bad year.

What they can and cannot do

Here's the part most women in this situation don't know, and it changes the calculation completely.

Nigeria's Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Commission issued the Digital, Electronic, Online or Non-Traditional Consumer Lending Regulations in 2025. They came into force on 21 July 2025 and they're aimed squarely at how these lenders behave when you fall behind.

Under those rules, a digital lender may not:

- Contact your friends, family, employer or colleagues to collect a debt
- Access your phone contacts, gallery or messages before a loan is approved
- Use abusive, threatening or defamatory language against you
- Publish your loan details, including posting about you on social media

Lenders are required to register with the FCCPC. Non-compliance carries penalties reported at up to ₦100 million or one percent of annual turnover, and directors can be disqualified from running a business for up to five years.

READ THIS IF THE MESSAGES HAVE STARTED

If a loan app has messaged your contacts, called your employer, or sent messages calling you a criminal or a thief, that conduct is prohibited under the 2025 regulations. It is not a normal part of owing money and you are not obliged to absorb it quietly. The FCCPC publishes its current complaint channels and its list of approved lenders on its official website at fccpc.gov.ng. Check there for the up-to-date process rather than relying on anything a collection agent tells you.

The debt itself is still real. Knowing the rules doesn't erase what you owe. What it does is separate two things that feel identical at 11pm when your aunt has just been sent a message

about you. The money is a problem you can work through. The harassment is prohibited conduct and somebody else's violation.

That separation is worth a great deal to a woman who currently believes she deserves all of it.

The rule, stated plainly

Do not borrow money for a partner. Not from an app, not from a cooperative, not from your employer, not from your mother.

If he needs money you don't have, the answer is that you don't have it. Script 5 in Chapter 4 is written for exactly that night.

Lending money you own is a decision with a known worst case. You lose it. Borrowing money for someone else is a decision whose worst case you don't control, because it keeps growing after everyone involved has stopped paying attention.

YOUR MOVE

If you have no loan-app debt, write one line in your notes: "I don't borrow for him. Ever." Date it. That is the whole action, and it will be there on the night you need it.

If you do have loan-app debt, do step one right now. The real figure, all apps, today.

What this chapter changes

You know how the number runs, why his repayment promise can't hold, and what the lender is legally barred from doing to you.

The outflow's closed, the old money's settled or written off, and the worst decision is off the table. What's left is every future request, and you need something better than deciding each one on the night.

CHAPTER 7: The Four Questions

It's 10:40pm. The message says *"babe abeg send 45k, I go explain tomorrow."*

You're tired. You've had a long day. He's been sweet all week and there hasn't been a request in nearly a month. You genuinely have the money, and if you send it now you can sleep, and if you don't you're going to lie there running it.

This is the exact condition in which you've made every bad decision in this book. Late, tired, fond of him, and deciding from scratch.

You're not going to decide from scratch anymore.

Why a rule beats a decision

Every request so far has been judged on its own merits. That sounds fair. It's the thing that's been costing you.

Judging each request separately means the decision gets made by whatever you're feeling at 10:40pm, and what you're feeling at 10:40pm is tired. He has one thing to argue and you have an entire evening of exhaustion working against you. You lose that one most nights.

A rule moves the decision to a time when you're not in it. Four questions, same four every time, answered before you reply. They take ninety seconds.

THE SHIFT THIS CHAPTER MAKES

Stop asking "should I send this?" and start asking "does this pass?" The first question has no answer and you will argue with yourself for an hour. The second has an answer in ninety seconds and it is the same answer whether you are rested or wrecked.

Buying yourself the ninety seconds

You can't run the questions with him watching the typing indicator. So the first move is always the same, and it's the only thing you send immediately.

SCRIPT 9, warm register.

"Let me check what I've got and come back to you in the morning."

SCRIPT 9, firm register.

"I don't make money decisions at night. I'll let you know tomorrow."

The warm one usually passes without comment. The firm one sometimes gets pushback, and the pushback is almost always urgency: it has to be tonight, the person is waiting, the shop closes.

When that happens, hold. *"Then I can't help with this one."* Genuine emergencies survive a night. The ones that can't survive a night are usually the ones manufacturing the pressure, and you'll notice over a few months how many of them quietly resolve themselves by morning.

The four questions

Answer all four before you reply. Write the answers down the first three or four times. After that you'll run them in your head.

Question one. Would I still send this if I knew for certain it was never coming back?

Not "will he pay it back". You already know your repayment rate from the tracker in Chapter 3.

If the honest answer is yes, this is a gift, and gifts are allowed. Give it cleanly and stop calling it a loan, because calling it a loan is how resentment builds in the background for two years.

If the answer is no, you were counting on repayment, and the tracker already told you what that's worth.

Question two. What in my own life moves if I send this?

Be concrete. Not "it'll be tight". Name the thing. Rent moves. The contribution moves. You borrow from next month's transport. You skip your sister's thing.

If something real moves, the answer is no, and it's no regardless of how good his reason is. You are not a bank with a reserve. Whatever you send is coming directly out of something else you needed.

Question three. Who else has he asked?

Ask him. Out loud, ordinary tone: *"Who else have you asked?"*

The answer matters less than the reaction. A man handling a genuine problem has usually tried two or three people and will tell you who. A man who's built an arrangement around one person tends to get uncomfortable, because the honest answer is nobody, because you've always said yes.

That discomfort is information and it costs you nothing to collect.

Question four. What is this actually for?

You're not investigating him. You're checking whether you know.

Halima was twenty-two. Reflecting on what her money had gone toward, she said: *"In an indirect way, I contributed to his drug addiction."*

She didn't know at the time. Almost nobody does. That's the point of asking, and of noticing when the answers stop being specific or stop arriving at all.

If you've sent money three times running without knowing what it was for, that's your answer to question four.

Scoring it

Simple. **Any single no means no.**

Not three out of four. Not a balance of considerations. One failed question and the answer is no, and you use Script 3 or Script 5 from Chapter 4 to deliver it.

That rigidity is deliberate. A rule with exceptions is a rule you'll negotiate with, and you already know who wins those negotiations at 10:40pm.

THE EXCEPTION YOU ARE ALREADY PLANNING

Right now you are thinking of the one situation where the rule shouldn't apply. His mother. A medical thing. A real emergency. Notice that you are building the exception before the situation has happened. That is what the last eight months have been. If a genuine emergency arrives, Script 5 lets you help within a limit you can actually carry, and that is a better answer than an open account.

The threshold

Run the four questions on anything above ₦20,000, or whatever figure represents real money in your life.

Below that, don't. You'd exhaust yourself and quit the system within two weeks. Small amounts are governed by the monthly ceiling you set in Chapter 4, and when the ceiling's reached, it's reached.

THE ONE-PAGE ARTIFACT

Write this in your notes app. Title it something dull he would never open.

Before any transfer over ₦20,000:

1. Would I send it if it never came back?
2. What in my life moves if I send it?
3. Who else has he asked?
4. What is it actually for?

Any single no means no.

My ceiling this month: ₦_____

Total given so far: ₦_____

DO THIS NOW

Write the four questions into your notes app tonight, with your ceiling and your total at the bottom. Then send Script 9 the next time a request arrives, before you do anything else. That one

message buys you every other decision in this book.

What this chapter changes

The next request doesn't get decided by how tired you are. It gets decided by four questions you wrote while you were thinking clearly, and one of them will usually answer it inside a minute.

Most relationships absorb this fine. He grumbles, adjusts, and it stops being a feature of how you two work.

Some don't. That's the last chapter.

CHAPTER 8: If It Does Not Survive the No

Six weeks in, one of two things has happened.

Either the requests thinned out and the relationship carried on, which happens more often than you'd think and is the boring outcome, or the whole thing has come apart, and he's told you that you've changed, that you're stingy now, that somebody has been talking to you.

If it's the second, read this chapter slowly. It's the one you'll want to argue with.

The two outcomes

He adjusts. Not gracefully. There'll be a bad week or two, some cold, a comment or two about how you've become different. Then it settles, because the arrangement was convenient rather than essential, and convenience adapts.

This happens more often than you'd think, and it's worth saying plainly, because women in the middle of this are convinced the relationship will not survive a single no. Often it does.

It ends. Either he goes, or the fights get frequent enough that you do.

Here's the sentence to hold onto if that's where you are.

THE ONLY CONCLUSION AVAILABLE

A relationship that ends because you stopped paying for it was telling you what it was. You did not break it by saying no. You found out what it was made of, at a cost of six weeks instead of six more years.

That won't feel like comfort tonight. It's still true, and in four months it'll be the thing you're most glad you did.

What he will say

Three things, roughly in this order.

"You've changed." Correct. That's the intended result. Changing is not a betrayal of anybody.

"Somebody is influencing you." Sometimes aimed at a friend, sometimes at a sister, sometimes at a book. What it's really asking is whether your decision is yours, and it's hoping the answer is no so it can be argued with. *"Nobody told me to do this."*

"After everything I've done for you." The hardest one, because there's usually something true underneath it. He probably has done things for you. Those things were not invoices, and they don't convert into a standing claim on your account.

Ending it cleanly

If you're leaving, or he is, two scripts. Pick the register that matches where you actually are.

SCRIPT 10, warm register.

"I've thought about this a lot and I don't want to keep going. The money made me into someone I don't like being with you, and I don't think that's fixable between us. I'm not angry with you. I just need to stop."

Usually provokes: an apology, a promise to change, sometimes a real one. If you want to test it, the test is six weeks with no requests, not a conversation.

SCRIPT 11, firm register.

"I'm done. I'm not discussing the money and I'm not going back and forth about it. Please don't ask me for anything else."

Usually provokes: anger first, then silence, then in a lot of cases a message four to eight weeks later that opens warmly and arrives at a request. You'll recognise it when it comes. You don't have to answer it.

Leaving, practically

The money part, which nobody covers and everybody needs.

Remove his access. Card, app, saved details, anything he can reach. If he's ever used your phone to send himself money, change the PIN today and don't discuss it.

Change your transfer PIN and your banking password. Not as an accusation. As ordinary hygiene at the end of a relationship where money moved.

Check for anything in your name. Subscriptions, a line of credit, a device plan, a loan app you opened. Close what you can.

Stop the standing transfer if there is one. Some women set up an automatic monthly transfer and forget it's running. Check.

Keep the tracker. Not for revenge. For the month when it starts feeling like it wasn't that bad, because that month is coming and the number is the only thing that will argue back.

Do not send a final accounting. The itemised list of everything you gave, delivered as a parting shot, feels like justice for about eleven minutes. It reopens everything and it never once has produced a payment.

When this is not a money problem

Some of what's in this book describes a relationship with a bad habit in it. Some of it describes something else, and the difference matters more than anything else in these pages.

It isn't a money problem if any of these are true.

- He holds your card, your phone or your account details and you can't get them back.
- You're afraid of what happens when you say no. Physically afraid.
- He controls what you spend, or requires an account of it.
- He's stopped you working, studying, or seeing people.
- He's taken money from your account without asking.
- He's threatened to share something about you if you refuse.

That's economic abuse and it usually travels with other kinds. It isn't a communication failure, it isn't something the scripts in Chapter 4 can reach, and it isn't something you caused by being too generous at the start.

Bisi, thirty-three, on ₦85,000 a month, described a partner who took her card and spent her ₦85,000 salary. Alongside it she said: *"I convinced myself I was lucky. I didn't think I could do better."*

Both sentences belong to the same situation. The second one is why the first one lasted.

IF YOU ARE LEAVING A SITUATION LIKE THIS

The point of leaving is the most dangerous point. Do not announce it in advance. Get your documents, your cards and your phone secure first, tell one person outside the relationship what you are doing, and use the services below rather than working it out alone. This is the one part of this book where the right move is to stop reading and call somebody.

Where to get real help

These services are free and confidential. They were checked when this book was written, and phone numbers do change, so if one doesn't connect, try another.

Lagos State Domestic and Sexual Violence Agency (DSVA). Free, confidential, and running 24 hours a day across Lagos State. Counsellors, medical support, free legal representation and access to a safe shelter. Phone **0800 033 3333**. Office at Novel House, Central Business District, Alausa, Ikeja. Online at lagosdsva.org.

Mirabel Centre, Lagos. Nigeria's first sexual assault referral centre. Free medical care, free tests and medication, and free counselling in person, online or by phone. Phone **0815 577 0000, 0701 349 1769 or 0818 724 3468**.

Women At Risk International Foundation (WARIF), Lagos. Counselling, medical care and help navigating the legal process.

Outside Lagos. findahelpline.com lists services by Nigerian state and is the fastest way to find something local. Your state's Ministry of Women Affairs also runs or refers to support services, and a Legal Aid Council office can advise at no cost.

IF MONEY IS THE ONLY THING THAT IS WRONG

Not every reader needs the services above, and that is a good thing rather than a sign you are minimising. If the honest description of your situation is that you love someone who takes advantage of your generosity and you have been letting him, that is a real problem with a practical answer, and the previous seven chapters are that answer. Use them.

What this chapter changes

You know both outcomes, you have words for either, and you know the difference between a relationship with a money problem and a situation that needs somebody on a phone tonight.

One thing left. What you do with the next request.

CONCLUSION: What You Do With the Next Request

Go back to the number.

The one you found in Chapter 3, forty minutes with your bank app, going back twelve months. Whatever it was, it's the truest thing in this book, because every other page is describing a pattern and that one is describing you.

Here's what's changed since you found it.

You know the escalation has stages and you know which one you're on. You know the three days of cold are a price rather than a verdict. You have four sentences for four situations, three ways to ask for money back, a rule about loan apps that could save you a year of your life, and four questions that decide the next request before you're too tired to decide it well.

None of that required you to leave him. Most of you won't have to.

The thing to remember when the rest fades

You'll forget the scripts. That's fine, they're in your phone.

What's worth keeping is the mechanism, because it's the piece that makes all of it work and it's the piece nobody had ever described to you before.

THE WHOLE BOOK IN FOUR SENTENCES

When you say no, he goes quiet. The quiet is not evidence that you hurt him, that you are selfish, or that you have damaged something. It is the price of the word no, and it has been set high because you have always paid it. Once you can name it while it is happening, it stops working.

That's it. Everything else in these pages is an application of it.

Where this actually gets decided

Not in a big conversation. There probably won't be one.

It gets decided at 10:40pm on an ordinary Tuesday when a message arrives asking for ₦45,000, and you send back one line asking to talk in the morning, and then you go to sleep instead of lying there arguing with yourself.

That's the whole thing. Not dramatic. Just different from what you've done every other Tuesday for the last eight months.

Your last action

One thing, tonight, before you put this down.

Open your notes app. Put in the four questions from Chapter 7, your monthly ceiling, and your total from Chapter 3. Title the note something dull.

Then screenshot Script 9 and keep it somewhere you can reach in under ten seconds, because the next request is coming and it won't announce itself.

When it arrives, you don't have to be strong. You don't have to have worked out what you feel about him, or what this means, or whether you're being fair.

You just have to send one line and go to bed.

If anything in this book described your situation more closely than you were comfortable with, that is not a coincidence and you are not the only one. The women in these pages are composites, but every part of their stories is something real women live through. That is the reason this book exists.

The Connection Code